Human-made Things in the Bible © United Bible Societies, 2025. Adapted from: The Works of Their Hands: Man-made Things in the Bible, by Ray Pritz © 2009 United Bible Societies. This work is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/).

Writing case

1.7.4 Writing case

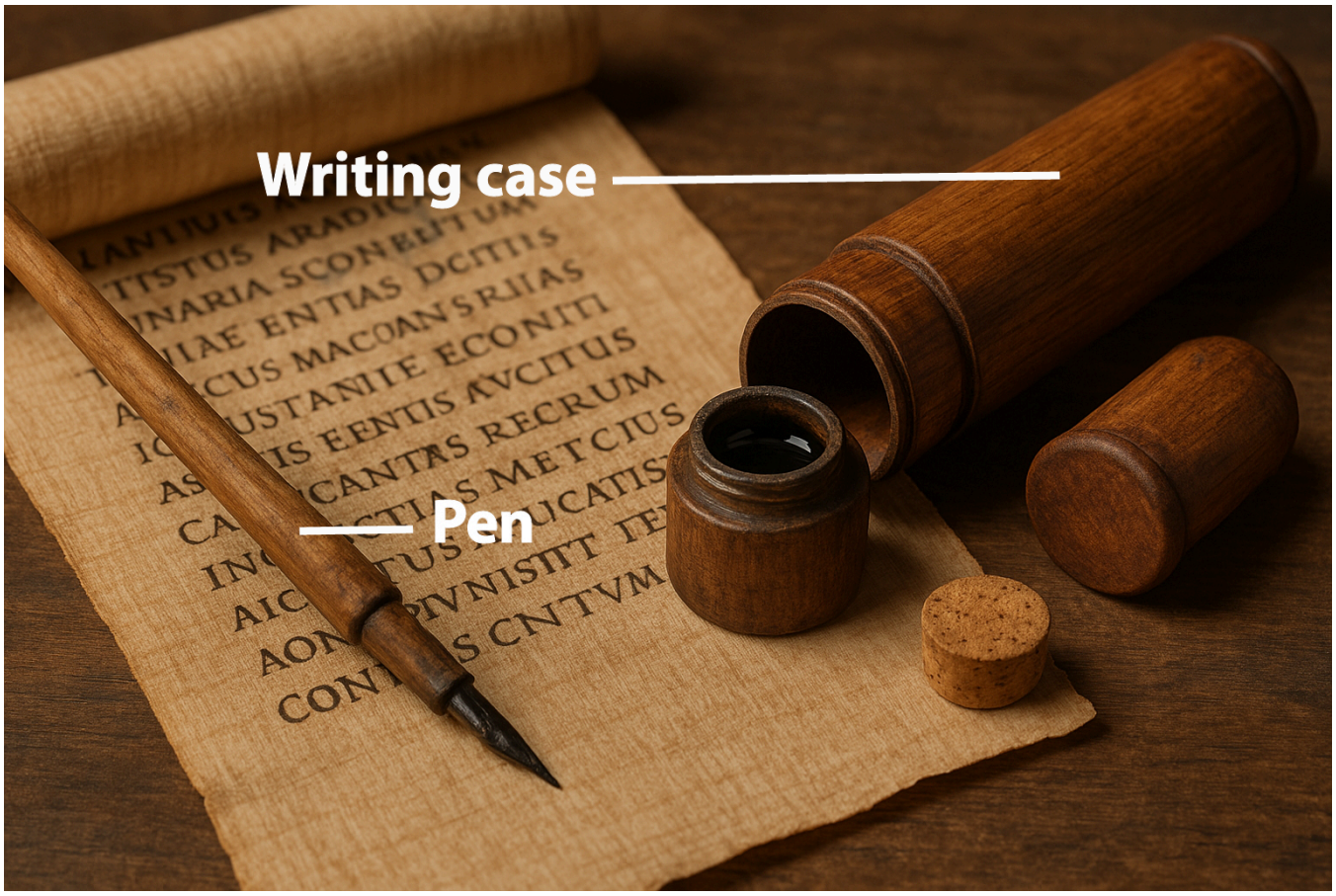
References:

Hebrew קֶסֶת, סֹפֵר (qeseth sofer) EZK 9:2, EZK 9:3, EZK 9:11

Description:

Pens in a case (Wood, ivory, paint, ca. 1635–1458 BCE, Second Intermediate Period–Early New Kingdom, Egypt, Thebes, Asasif) (Metropolitan Museum of Art, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons)The writing case was a small box, usually made of wood, for carrying several pens (1.7.2) and sometimes a cake of dried ink (1.7.4). Inside the case, in addition to several reed pens, there were receptacles where the ink was mixed at the time of writing. A person generally carried this case by hanging it from his belt. Sometimes the object for mixing the ink had the shape of a palette, with two circular hollows for two colors of ink, and was carried by hanging it from a cord.

Translation:



Writing case and pen (Image generated by ChatGPT using OpenAI technology)The closest equivalent in many languages for “writing case” would be “pencil case,” but this could sound anachronistic. It is also possible to render it with a descriptive phrase, such as “a small box in which he carried pens” or “… in which he carried writing instruments.”